



NECTAR OF THE GODS

Expensive, French and usually seen glistening on the top shelves of bars, cognac is elusive. Here's everything you need to know about the classic spirit

BY SMITA TRIPATHI

V *of Les Miserables* fame described cognac as 'the liquor of the gods'. So what makes the amber liquid so special to be given such an exalted status? "Cognac is distilled white wine which is then aged for years. Sometimes for decades, as is the case for Louis XIII. It comes only from the Cognac region in Southwest France," says Malo Le Mestre, Brand Ambassador in India for Louis XIII, one of the world's most exclusive cognac brands.

The history of cognac stretches back to the 1600s. The story goes that it was the Dutch who wanted to carry wine from France to the Netherlands. But it did not travel well. So they decided to distil it. At first it was distilled only once, probably to keep it as close to wine. However, they soon figured that double distillation created a far smoother drink. And so was formed 'brandwijn' or burnt wine or what we today call brandy. The French then further refined the process. While all cognac is brandy, not all brandy is cognac, similar to how all champagne is sparkling wine but not all sparkling wine is champagne. The French seem to have a fascination for such things.

So what is cognac exactly? Cognac is an exclusive type of brandy produced from distilled white wine made from white grapes from three varietals grown in Cognac: Colombard, Folle Blanche and Ugni Blanc (with a large majority being made from Ugni Blanc). It must be distilled twice,